

Medieval eastern Europe

Eastern Europe—which stretches from the Baltic Sea to the Black Sea, and includes western Russia—changed dramatically during the medieval period. Some areas were settled by tribes from the east, and across the region different peoples came together to form new countries. Christianity spread, and soon became eastern Europe's major religion.

Much of the region came under the sway of the Eastern Orthodox Church, which was based in the capital of the Byzantine Empire, Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul). The religious influence of the Byzantine Empire led to cultural influence as well. For example, Byzantine missionaries adapted the Greek alphabet into the Cyrillic script, still used in Russia and parts of southeastern Europe today. The Byzantine Empire had less

OLEG OF NOVGOROD

The Viking warrior Oleg of Novgorod (c.845–912) is believed to have founded Kievan Rus, the first Russian state. He attacked the mighty Byzantine Empire in 907, and threatened to destroy the city of Constantinople unless he was paid. In 911, he negotiated a lucrative trade agreement with the empire.



influence over Poland, however, which adopted the Catholic faith in the 10th century, and developed closer links to western Europe.

Various states and kingdoms emerged in eastern Europe during the medieval period, including Poland, Bulgaria, Serbia, Hungary, and the Kievan Rus (the ancestor of present-day Russia, Belarus, and Ukraine). They traded with the growing Byzantine Empire, and some of them, including Bulgaria, formed part of it for a time.

Image of
Mieszko I on
a Polish coin



▲ EARLY POLAND

Mieszko I, the founder of the first independent Polish state, adopted Catholicism in 966, making Poland a Christian country. Under his successor, Bolesław the Brave, Poland became a major European power, but it broke apart again into smaller states in the 12th century.

Árpád, head of
the tribes, founded the
Hungarian nation.

